PRACTICE 2 - EXAMPLES OF A QUALITATIVE RESEARCH

Analysing the Media and Communication Market by Qualitative Methods

Vietnam and the Platform Economy, 2021-2025

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Executive Summary

This report uses a qualitative research design to explain how media and communication in Vietnam changed during 2021-2025. Rather than treating change only as a set of numerical trends, the study asks how the meaning of 'audience,' the organization of content distribution, and newsroom practice have been reconstructed by mobile connectivity, social platforms, creator culture, on-demand media, data analytics, and artificial intelligence. The evidence base is a purposive sample of official policy documents, industry reports, platform materials, peer-reviewed journalism and platform studies, and Vietnamese case evidence. These materials were coded thematically around audience agency, platform power, creator participation, newsroom transformation, and business-model adaptation (Hase et al., 2023; Nielsen & Fletcher, 2023; Vu et al., 2020).

The central finding is that the Vietnamese media market has not simply moved from print and broadcasting to websites. It has become platformized. Audiences increasingly encounter news and entertainment through feeds, search, short-form video, messaging, recommendations, notifications, podcasts, and creator channels. By early 2025, Vietnam had 79.8 million internet users and 76.2 million social-media user identities; Facebook's potential advertising reach was also reported at 76.2 million and YouTube's at 62.3 million. These numbers are used only as contextual markers, because DataReportal cautions that advertising reach and social-media identity measures are not equivalent to unique active users (Kemp, 2025). Qualitatively, the important point is that platform use is embedded in everyday media routines at national scale.

GAFA does not operate as one homogeneous block. Google is especially influential through Search, YouTube, advertising technology, Android and analytics; Meta's Facebook and Instagram organize social discovery, sharing and creator visibility; Amazon combines advertising, cloud infrastructure, Prime Video, Audible and Twitch, with Twitch exemplifying participatory live media; and Apple shapes access through devices, the App Store, Podcasts, Music and subscription services. In Vietnam, Google and Meta are the most visible audience-distribution actors among the four, while Amazon and Apple are more significant as infrastructure, commerce, app-distribution and on-demand media ecosystems. The common feature is their ability to connect content, identity, data, recommendation and monetization in ways that legacy media organizations usually cannot reproduce at comparable scale (Helmond, 2015; Nielsen & Fletcher, 2023).

Vietnamese press organizations are actively responding. The 2023 national Press Digital Transformation Strategy formalized goals for professional, modern and reader-oriented digital newsrooms (Prime Minister of Vietnam, 2023). The 2024 maturity assessment shows progress but also unevenness: 28 of 282 assessed agencies were rated excellent, while 109 were rated poor. Case evidence from the Vietnam News Agency and VietnamPlus illustrates the shift toward mobile-first distribution, multimedia, data journalism, newsletters, AI-assisted production, analytics, podcasts, virtual and augmented reality, and social platforms (Vietnam News Agency, 2025). The qualitative conclusion is therefore two-sided: change is rapid and structural, but capabilities and business models are developing at different speeds across organizations.

1. Research Background and Questions

1.1 Background: from digital publishing to platformized media

The last five years are best understood as a transition from digitization to platformization. Digitization means converting content and processes into digital form; platformization refers to a deeper reorganization in which platform infrastructures and their economic logics become embedded in production, distribution, measurement and monetization. Helmond (2015) describes platformization as the extension of platform features into the wider web, while Nielsen and Fletcher (2023) emphasize the increasing role of platforms in how people access information, including news. For Vietnamese media, this distinction matters because a newspaper can have a website and still remain dependent on Facebook referrals, Google search, YouTube video distribution, mobile operating systems and third-party analytics. Digital presence is therefore not the same as strategic digital autonomy.

Vietnam offers a strong case for qualitative analysis because several processes have occurred simultaneously. Internet access reached mass scale; social media became an everyday distribution environment; short-form video and creator culture changed expectations for format and speed; advertisers gained access to granular targeting and performance measurement; and newsroom organizations began formal digital-transformation programs. The national Press Digital Transformation Strategy adopted in 2023 makes these changes explicit at policy level, including goals related to digital platforms, modern technology, audience experience and new revenue sources (Prime Minister of Vietnam, 2023). The speed of change can therefore be observed not only in technologies but also in the language used by institutions to describe the future of journalism.

1.2 Research questions

- RQ1: How did the social meaning and behavior of the media audience change in Vietnam during 2021-2025?
- RQ2: How do Google, Amazon, Facebook/Meta and Apple shape user-generated content, creator participation and on-demand media?
- RQ3: How is digital transformation changing the organization, formats, skills, technology and audience relationships of Vietnamese press and media?
- RQ4: What recurring themes show that the Vietnamese media and communication market changed rapidly during the five-year period?

1.3 Scope and terminology

The report uses 'GAFA' because it is the term specified in the assignment. Facebook, Inc. changed its corporate name to Meta Platforms in 2021, so 'Facebook/Meta' is used where appropriate. 'User-generated content' (UGC) refers broadly to media produced or circulated by users and creators rather than exclusively by institutional publishers. 'On-demand' refers to user-controlled access to media at a chosen time, including streaming video, podcasts and searchable or recommended digital content. The period of analysis is 2021-2025; older academic sources are used only to explain concepts that remain relevant to the current platform environment.

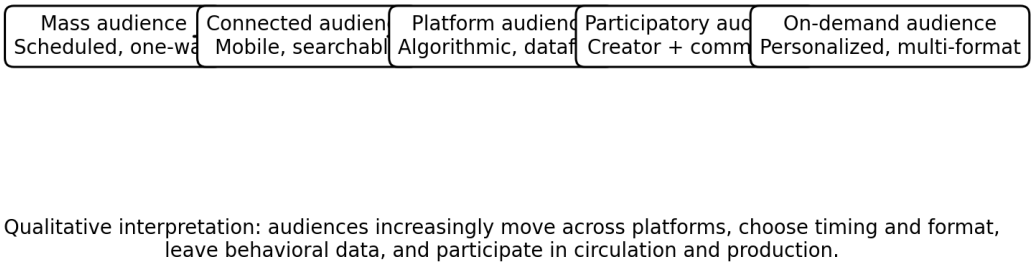


Figure 1. Conceptual transition in the role of the media audience.

Source: Author synthesis based on Helmond (2015), Willig (2022), Nielsen and Fletcher (2023), and the Vietnam evidence reviewed in this report.

2. Qualitative Methodology

2.1 Research design

This is a desk-based qualitative study using thematic document analysis and comparative case interpretation. The unit of analysis is not an individual respondent but a meaningful statement, practice, institutional development or platform feature that describes how media relationships are changing. The method is suitable because the assignment asks for a broad explanation of market change and because relevant evidence is distributed across policy documents, industry statistics, company materials, scholarly research and newsroom case reports. The approach follows a logic of triangulation: a theme is treated as stronger when it appears across different source types rather than relying on one organization or one numerical indicator.

2.2 Source selection

Sources were selected purposively rather than randomly. Four groups were prioritized. First, annual DataReportal reports provide consistent contextual evidence on Vietnamese internet and platform reach, while their methodological warnings help prevent over-interpretation (Kemp, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025). Second, Vietnamese government and Ministry of Information and Communications materials document the institutional definition and measurement of press digital transformation (Ministry of Information and Communications, 2024; Prime Minister of Vietnam, 2023). Third, peer-reviewed studies provide concepts such as platformization, datafication, social-media adaptation and newsroom routines (Hase et al., 2023; Nielsen & Fletcher, 2023; Vu et al., 2020; Willig, 2022). Fourth, case material from the Vietnam News Agency, VietnamPlus and platform companies illustrates concrete practices such as AI, analytics, multimedia, podcasts, live streaming and app distribution.

2.3 Coding and analysis

The material was read using five initial codes: (1) audience agency, (2) platform intermediation, (3) creator participation, (4) newsroom and workflow transformation, and (5) monetization and organizational capability. During analysis, subthemes were added for mobile-first use, algorithmic discovery, personalization, multi-format storytelling, data ownership, AI adoption, trust and skills. The purpose of coding was not to count how many times a word appeared, but to identify repeated mechanisms and relationships. For example, 'mobile-first,' 'short-form video' and 'notifications' were interpreted together as signs of a shift from scheduled media consumption toward continuous and context-dependent access.

2.4 Trustworthiness and limitations

Several safeguards are used. Claims about Vietnam are separated from global academic generalizations; platform advertising-reach figures are not treated as unique monthly users; and company materials are interpreted as descriptions of platform capabilities rather than independent evidence of social impact. The study also distinguishes rapid adoption from successful transformation. A newsroom may use AI or social media while still lacking a coherent data, revenue or product strategy. Finally, this report does not include original interviews or ethnographic observation. Its findings should therefore be read as a structured interpretation of secondary evidence, suitable for course research and for generating questions that could later be tested through interviews, focus groups or newsroom observation.

3. Qualitative Analysis of the Changing Audience

3.1 From receiver to participant

Traditional mass communication assumes a relatively clear separation between producers and audiences: editors and broadcasters produce, audiences receive, and feedback is limited or delayed. Platform media blur this boundary. Users comment, share, remix, livestream, upload video, create memes, react in real time and sometimes become professional creators. Kim's (2012) analysis of YouTube showed early tension between UGC and professional content, and later platform research shows that creator participation is increasingly organized by algorithms, metrics and monetization rules rather than by an entirely open public sphere. In Vietnam, this change is visible in the everyday coexistence of institutional news, influencers, livestreams, entertainment clips, citizen footage and branded content inside the same feeds. The audience is therefore simultaneously consumer, distributor, data source and potential producer.

3.2 From scheduled use to on-demand and mobile use

A second change concerns time. Broadcast schedules and print publication cycles still exist, but mobile media allow users to choose when and where to consume content. Search, video-on-demand, podcasts, replay, notifications and social feeds create a continuous media environment. This increases convenience but also intensifies competition for attention, because news no longer competes only with other news outlets; it competes with games, creators, entertainment, shopping and messaging in the same device interface. The growth of internet access from 68.72 million users in 2021 to 79.8 million in early 2025 provides the infrastructure for this behavior, while the near-national scale of Facebook and YouTube advertising reach illustrates the availability of large platform audiences (Kemp, 2021, 2025).

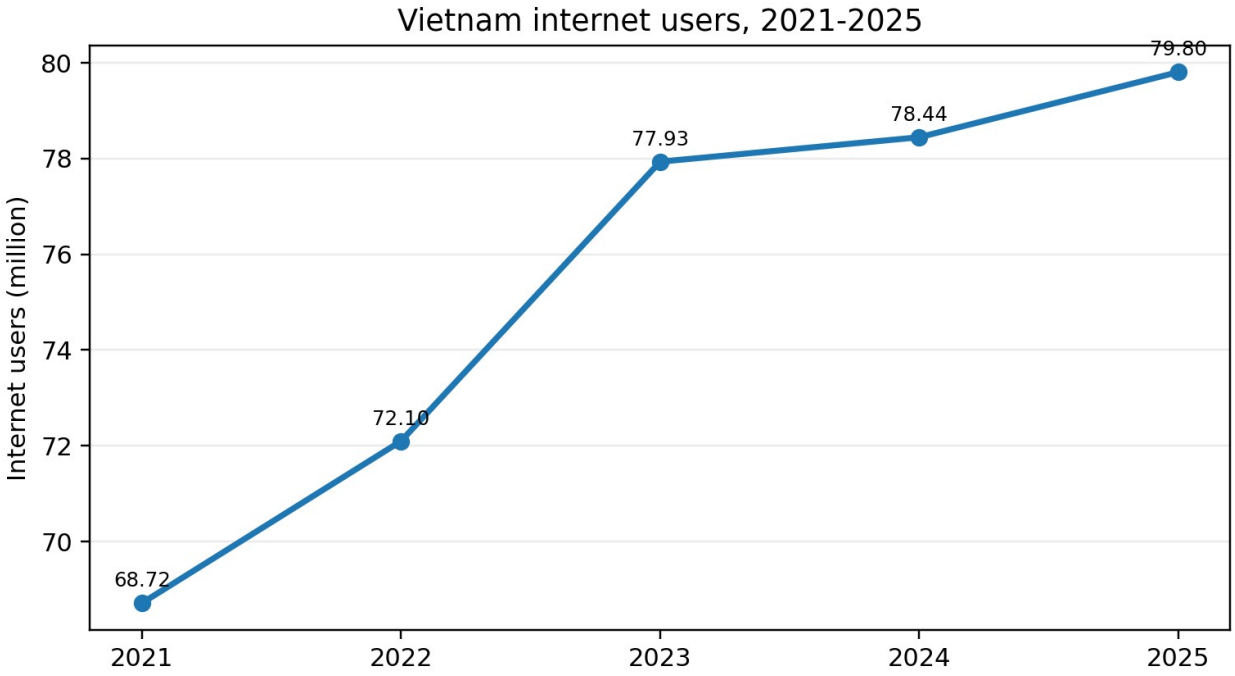


Figure 2. Internet adoption as context for changing audience behavior in Vietnam.

Source: Kemp (2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025). DataReportal notes that annual data sources and methodologies can be revised.

3.3 From direct destination to algorithmic discovery

A third change is the weakening of the assumption that audiences begin with the homepage of a media brand. Nielsen and Fletcher (2023) show internationally that platformization varies by country, but social platforms have become major gateways to information. Algorithmic feeds and search results select which items become visible, while recommendation systems personalize sequences of content. The consequence for publishers is a change from destination logic to discovery logic. A newsroom must still maintain its own website or app, but it also has to design headlines, thumbnails, video formats, metadata, posting rhythms and engagement practices for external platforms. Hase et al. (2023) describe this as adaptation to platform affordances: news organizations may technically and editorially adjust content to fit different social environments.

3.4 From demographic audience to datafied audience

The audience is also increasingly represented as data. Page views, watch time, completion rate, click-through rate, search terms, subscriptions, newsletter opens, shares and conversion events turn behavior into measurable signals. Willig (2022) argues that contemporary media markets transform audiences into data points that can be segmented and commodified.

For Vietnamese newsrooms, analytics can improve editorial relevance and product design, but dependence on third-party platforms creates an asymmetry: the platform often observes a richer set of cross-service behaviors than the publisher does. This makes first-party data - information collected directly from registered users, subscribers or newsletter readers - strategically important for building a durable audience relationship.

3.5 Fragmentation, trust and the hybrid news-entertainment environment

Audience choice does not necessarily produce a single unified digital public. Personalization, creator cultures and short-form video can fragment attention into topic communities and individualized feeds. A 2025 study of Vietnamese Generation Z and TikTok found that news use was shaped by perceived usefulness, compatibility, motivation, entertainment and convenience, underscoring the hybrid nature of platforms that combine information with entertainment (Factors Driving Gen Z's News Engagement on TikTok, 2025). For journalism, the qualitative challenge is to be engaging without losing verification, context and professional identity. The more news appears inside mixed-content feeds, the more important recognizable branding, source transparency and distinctive editorial value become.

4. GAFA and the Reorganization of UGC and On-Demand Media

4.1 Google: search, YouTube and the visibility infrastructure

Google's role is broader than a search engine. Search organizes discovery; YouTube hosts creator, professional and hybrid video; Google advertising tools connect audiences and advertisers; Android and Google Play shape mobile distribution; and analytics and cloud services support production and measurement. YouTube is particularly important for UGC because it combines low barriers to publishing with algorithmic recommendation, subscription channels, advertising and creator monetization. Van Es (2020) argues that YouTube's operational logic gives metrics such as the 'view' a powerful role in ordering visibility and value. For media organizations, this means that video success is partly determined by editorial quality and partly by platform-specific signals such as retention, engagement, metadata and recommendation performance.

4.2 Facebook/Meta: social graph, feeds and creator circulation

Facebook and Meta's wider family of apps place social interaction at the center of distribution. News, personal updates, community posts, creator video and advertising appear in the same feed environment. This changes the pathway through which journalism is encountered: users may reach a news story because a friend shared it, because a page posted it, because the platform recommended it, or because an advertiser paid for reach. Research on Vietnamese journalists found that Facebook had already become routinized for reporting, understanding audiences and professional branding, showing that platform use affects production as well as distribution (Vu et al., 2020). During 2021-2025, the growth of Reels and short-form video intensified pressure on publishers to communicate through platform-native formats rather than simply posting links.

4.3 Amazon: on-demand entertainment, live creators and infrastructure

Amazon is less dominant than Google or Meta as a social news gateway in Vietnam, but it remains relevant to the media ecosystem through several layers. Prime Video and Audible are on-demand services; Twitch is a major live, interactive creator platform; Amazon advertising connects commercial intent and media buying; and Amazon Web Services provides cloud infrastructure used across digital businesses. Twitch describes its service as a place where streamers build communities and audiences participate in live entertainment, illustrating a form of UGC in which chat and community interaction are integral to the product (Twitch, n.d.). Amazon's media role therefore demonstrates that platform power can be infrastructural and commercial even when a company's consumer-facing news presence is limited.

4.4 Apple: device, app and subscription gatekeeping

Apple's importance lies primarily in the device and app ecosystem rather than in a Facebook-style social network. The App Store determines a major route through which publishers, podcast services, video apps and creator tools reach iPhone and iPad users. Apple Podcasts and Apple Music support on-demand audio, while Apple TV services compete for subscription attention. Apple reported that the App Store ecosystem attracted more than 813 million average weekly visitors worldwide in 2024, illustrating the distribution scale of the ecosystem even though this figure is global rather than Vietnam-specific (Apple, 2025). For media organizations, Apple's role highlights a different dimension of platformization: access to audiences may depend on operating-system rules, app-store discovery, payment systems and device-level user experience.

4.5 Comparative interpretation: GAFA is an ecosystem, not one market

Company	Primary media role	UGC / creator role	On-demand role	Strategic issue for press
Google / Alphabet	Search, YouTube, ads, Android	YouTube channels, comments, creator monetization	YouTube, YouTube Music/Premium	Discovery and ad-tech dependence
Facebook / Meta	Social feeds, messaging, ads	Posts, groups, Reels, creators, sharing	Feed and video consumption on demand	Referral volatility and algorithmic visibility
Amazon	Commerce ads, cloud, Twitch, subscriptions	Twitch live streamers and communities	Prime Video, Audible, Twitch VOD	Infrastructure and commerce-media convergence
Apple	Devices, App Store, services	App-based creator tools; podcasts	Podcasts, Music, TV services	App distribution, payments and device ecosystem

The comparison shows why equal treatment of the four companies would be misleading. Google and Meta are most directly connected to the daily discovery and circulation of user-generated and news content; Amazon combines creator media with commerce and cloud infrastructure; Apple controls a premium device and app-distribution layer. What they share is the ability to bundle multiple functions - identity, discovery, hosting, recommendation, data, payments or advertising - inside ecosystems with strong network effects. Traditional press organizations usually participate in these

ecosystems as content suppliers and advertisers while simultaneously trying to protect direct relationships with their audiences.

5. Qualitative Analysis of Digital Transformation of Press and Media in Vietnam

5.1 Transformation as organizational change, not website modernization

Vietnam's Press Digital Transformation Strategy to 2025, with orientation to 2030, defines transformation in broad institutional terms. Its goals include professional and modern news organizations, effective audience experiences, stronger digital platforms, new revenue sources and development of the digital-content industry (Prime Minister of Vietnam, 2023). This framing is important because it rejects a narrow idea that digital transformation simply means publishing the same article online. In qualitative terms, transformation changes the newsroom's product logic, workflows, skills, infrastructure, performance indicators and relationship with audiences.

5.2 Multi-platform production and format convergence

A transformed newsroom produces one story for multiple forms of use. Text may be accompanied by short video, long-form interactive graphics, podcast audio, data visualization, newsletters, social posts or live discussion. Vietnam News Agency case evidence shows this convergence in practice. VietnamPlus has used long-form features, infographics, videographics, data journalism, virtual and augmented reality, newsletters and social channels, while other VNA units have expanded podcasts, 360-degree images and multimedia packages (Vietnam News Agency, 2025). The significance is not simply aesthetic. Multi-format production changes planning: editors must decide which platform and format best fits the audience need, not only which section of a newspaper will carry the story.

5.3 Analytics, personalization and product thinking

Digital transformation also makes audience behavior part of editorial and product decision-making. According to the VNA's 2025 description of its digital shift, VietnamPlus uses analytics and data tools to understand reader behavior, personalize newsletters and support editorial decisions; it also maintains web-push and account-based relationships rather than relying only on anonymous visits (Vietnam News Agency, 2025). This illustrates product thinking: a newsroom designs recurring user experiences - a newsletter, app, podcast, membership flow or personalized homepage - rather than seeing each article as an isolated output. Such practices can strengthen direct audience relationships and reduce complete dependence on social referral traffic.

5.4 AI and automation: fast adoption, uneven strategic depth

AI became a visible part of newsroom transformation by the end of the five-year period. A 2025 national press forum discussion cited survey evidence that more than 60% of media agencies had applied or planned to apply AI in 2024, about double the level reported for 2023. However, use was concentrated in tasks such as headline suggestions, summarization, editing, translation and image/video production, while strategic applications in audience analysis and business modeling remained limited (Vietnam News Agency, 2025b). Qualitatively, this shows a familiar pattern: tool adoption can move faster than organizational redesign. The competitive benefit of AI depends on governance, data quality, training, integration with workflows and a clear editorial purpose.

5.5 Capability differences across the press system

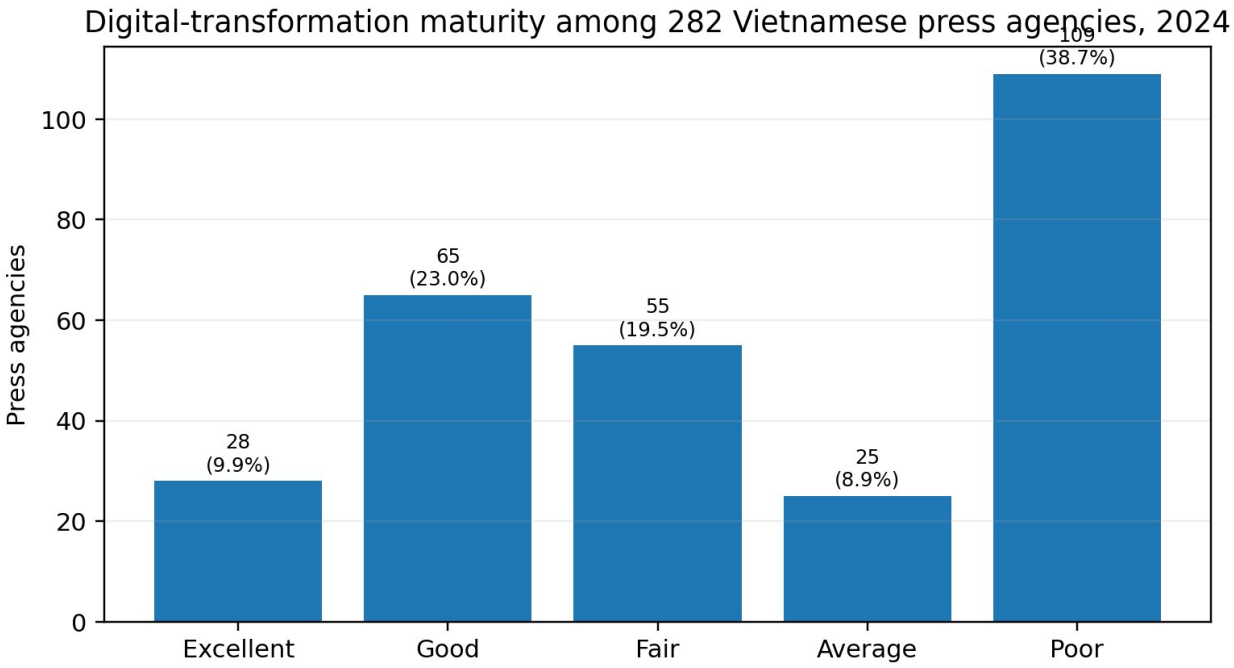


Figure 3. Digital-transformation maturity distribution, 2024.

Source: Vietnam News Agency (2024) reporting the Authority of Press assessment. The figure is contextual evidence within a qualitative interpretation.

The 2024 maturity results capture the unevenness of transformation. Among 282 participating organizations, 28 were rated excellent, 65 good, 55 fair, 25 average and 109 poor. The assessment framework considered strategy, digital infrastructure and security, organizational-professional alignment, audiences, and technology adoption (Ministry of Information and Communications, 2024; Vietnam News Agency, 2024). These categories support a qualitative conclusion: digital transformation is no longer exceptional, but it is not uniform. Leading organizations have moved toward integrated digital ecosystems, while many smaller or resource-constrained outlets still face gaps in technology, skills, strategy and revenue.

6. Five-Year Thematic Synthesis: Why the Market Changed Rapidly

Theme	2021-2025 qualitative evidence	Meaning for the market
Audience agency	Mobile, on-demand, sharing, commenting, creators, short video	Audiences choose timing, format and circulation pathways.
Platform intermediation	Search, feeds, recommendations, app stores and creator platforms	Visibility increasingly depends on external infrastructures and algorithms.
Datafication	Analytics, ad targeting, watch time, first-party accounts and personalization	Audience relationships are measured and monetized through behavioral data.
Newsroom convergence	Multimedia, podcasts, newsletters, data journalism, AI, cloud and social distribution	Journalistic production becomes multi-format, continuous and technology-intensive.
Economic adaptation	Platform ads, subscriptions, creator monetization, direct user relationships	Legacy advertising is no longer the only viable revenue logic; product and data strategy matter.

6.1 Speed is visible in simultaneous change across several layers

The strongest evidence of rapid change is the simultaneity of the transition. An audience shift alone could be treated as changing consumer preference; a technology shift alone could be treated as modernization; and a revenue shift alone could be treated as a business cycle. In Vietnam during 2021-2025, however, these processes reinforced one another. More people were connected; platforms became major points of discovery; formats became shorter, more visual and more interactive; newsrooms adopted analytics, cloud tools and AI; and policy moved from general digitalization toward a formal press-transformation strategy. When multiple layers change in the same direction, the market structure itself is changing.

6.2 The key structural shift is from channel control to ecosystem participation

Traditional media organizations historically controlled most stages between production and consumption: the newspaper controlled printing and distribution, and broadcasters controlled channels and schedules. In the platform era, those stages are distributed across ecosystems. A newsroom may create a video, edit it with third-party tools, host it on YouTube, promote it on Facebook, reach users through Android or iOS, measure it with analytics and monetize it through platform advertising. This creates new capabilities and enormous reach, but it also means that crucial rules - recommendation, ranking, data access, ad formats, app policies - can be set outside the newsroom. The market therefore changes from channel competition to ecosystem negotiation.

6.3 Audience-centered transformation is the common response

Across official strategy documents and leading newsroom cases, 'audience' becomes a design principle rather than a passive endpoint. The 2024 maturity index gives substantial weight to readers, viewers and listeners, and leading Vietnamese digital-news cases emphasize personalization, mobile access, newsletters, web push, social media and new formats. This is consistent with international research showing that news organizations adapt to platform affordances and audience expectations (Hase et al., 2023). The practical implication is that editorial quality remains necessary, but quality has to be delivered through experiences that are discoverable, usable and relevant within contemporary media routines.

7. Discussion

7.1 Opportunities

Digital transformation creates opportunities that were difficult for traditional media to achieve. A local newsroom can reach national or international audiences without physical distribution; multimedia can explain complex stories through data, video and interactivity; analytics can reveal unmet audience needs; podcasts and newsletters can build recurring habits; and automation can reduce routine production time. UGC can also provide leads, eyewitness material and community knowledge, provided verification standards are applied. Platforms therefore should not be described only as threats. They are both infrastructures of opportunity and sources of dependence.

7.2 Risks and tensions

The same mechanisms create risks. Algorithmic distribution can reward engagement in ways that may not align with public-interest journalism. Short-form and entertainment-oriented formats can pressure news organizations to simplify context. Platform dependence can reduce control over audience data and expose publishers to sudden changes in referral traffic or monetization rules. Creator content expands voice and diversity but increases verification burdens. AI can raise productivity while also introducing risks related to accuracy, bias, copyright, disclosure and synthetic media. These tensions explain why digital transformation requires editorial governance and organizational strategy rather than technology adoption alone.

7.3 What qualitative analysis adds to the quantitative picture

Quantitative indicators can show that internet use rises, platform reach is large or media revenue changes. Qualitative analysis explains how and why those numbers matter. For example, a large Facebook audience is not only a reach statistic; it represents a different distribution logic based on feeds, social interaction, recommendation and advertising data. A newsroom's AI adoption rate is not only a percentage; it raises questions about workflow, decision rights, skills and verification. The combination of numerical context and thematic interpretation therefore provides a stronger background for a final research paper than either approach alone.

7.4 Limitations and future research

The report relies on secondary sources and publicly visible cases, which may over-represent organizations with successful digital initiatives. Future research could interview editors from central and local media, conduct focus groups with different age cohorts, compare how users discover the same news story across Facebook, YouTube, TikTok and publisher websites, or observe newsroom workflows before and after AI deployment. A particularly useful design would compare a digitally mature outlet with a lower-maturity outlet to examine which capabilities - leadership, data, technology, skills, business model or audience strategy - explain the difference.

8. Conclusion and Research Implications

The qualitative evidence supports the conclusion that Vietnam's media and communication market changed rapidly during 2021-2025. The defining change is not merely that content moved online. Audiences became mobile, on-demand, participatory and datafied; discovery increasingly moved through platform search, feeds and recommendation; creator and professional content converged inside shared environments; and newsrooms began reorganizing around multimedia products, analytics, cloud infrastructure, AI and direct digital relationships. Government strategy and maturity assessment institutionalized this transformation as a sector-wide objective, while case evidence shows what advanced implementation looks like.

GAFA's role should be interpreted by function rather than by treating the four firms as identical. Google and Meta are central to discovery, social distribution and digital advertising; Amazon illustrates the integration of commerce, cloud infrastructure, live creators and subscription media; Apple shapes app distribution, devices and on-demand services. Together, these ecosystems change the bargaining environment for traditional publishers because access, data, monetization and audience attention are increasingly organized by platform infrastructures.

For a final graded assessment, three arguments are especially defensible. First, audience change is structural because the user now controls more aspects of timing, format and circulation. Second, platformization changes both journalism and its business model because external infrastructures mediate visibility, data and advertising. Third, Vietnamese press transformation is rapid but uneven: leading organizations demonstrate sophisticated digital products, while the maturity distribution shows that many agencies still face capability gaps. These conclusions can be developed further through interviews, case comparison or mixed-method analysis.

Practical recommendations for Vietnamese media organizations

- Build first-party audience relationships through registration, newsletters, apps, web push and membership rather than relying only on social referrals.
- Treat social platforms as distribution partners but maintain owned websites, apps, databases and editorial brands as strategic assets.
- Organize multimedia production around audience needs and platform-specific use cases instead of simply republishing the same content everywhere.
- Develop newsroom-wide AI governance covering verification, disclosure, copyright, data security, human review and evaluation of productivity gains.
- Invest in product, data and revenue skills alongside editorial skills so digital transformation can create sustainable value, not only more digital output.

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Appendix A. Qualitative Coding Framework

Code	Guiding question	Examples of evidence
Audience agency	How much control does the user have over timing, selection, circulation or production?	On-demand viewing, comments, shares, creator uploads, newsletters
Platform intermediation	Which external system influences discovery or access?	Search ranking, feed recommendation, app stores, notifications
Datafication	How is audience behavior converted into data?	Watch time, clicks, registrations, analytics, ad targeting
Newsroom transformation	What changes inside production and organization?	Multimedia workflows, AI, cloud, product teams, mobile-first planning
Monetization	How is value captured?	Advertising, subscriptions, creator revenue, memberships, branded content
Capability gap	What prevents or slows transformation?	Skills, funding, strategy, infrastructure, data access, governance

Suggested interview questions for a follow-up primary study

- How has your newsroom changed the way it defines and measures its audience since 2021?
- Which platforms are most important for discovery, and what risks arise from depending on them?
- Which digital formats have changed editorial workflows most significantly?
- How are AI tools governed and checked before publication?
- Which revenue models appear most realistic for reducing dependence on traditional advertising?
- What capability - technology, people, data, leadership or finance - is the biggest constraint on transformation?

Methodological note: The appendix is designed so the report can be extended into interviews or a comparative case study. The same codes can be applied to transcripts and then compared with the secondary-document findings above.